Inflation of Division:

How American Mainstream News Misrepresents American Opinions to Create an Inflated View of Polarization and Division

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Introduction

There are awesome crises facing the American people and the world: increasing inequality, geopolitical tensions, the climate crisis, and the aftermath of a pandemic, to name a few. There is a growing consensus that the U.S. political system is incapable of dealing with these issues in a significant way, in part because of a sense that the nation is divided. Without unity, there is an assumption that it is difficult, perhaps impossible, to resolve these crises. But what if we *are* already united, at least more united than we think?

There are a range of ways one could assess American division or lack thereof. One could analyze how people vote, who their friends are, or what their socioeconomic positions are. Or, one could get a sense of American political polarization by directly asking people their opinions, such as with polling. As I will explore further in this paper, Americans perceive themselves to be extremely polarized while simultaneously agreeing on a series of "contentious issues" (Peoples and Fingerhut 2020).

The paper begins with a literature review, discussing how media is analyzed through multiple conceptual frameworks. Afterwards, I discuss my methodology for analyzing mainstream media's coverage of American opinions. The paper then provides the relevant background information, discussing where Americans stand on political issues, the U.S. electoral system, and propaganda in the U.S. I then analyze mainstream news coverage of U.S. division and how, through framing, tone, and omission, the news consistently misrepresents American viewpoints to inflate the level of division. To be clear, I am not making a normative judgment about political values. Distinguishing between stated values and "true" values is out of scope for this paper. Instead, I focus strictly on contrasting Americans' stated preferences with major news coverage of said preferences.

Literature Review

My media analysis aims to reveal the mechanisms by which the mainstream media distorts information around polarization. Such distortion stems from the larger context of propaganda systems and media disinformation. As the focus of my research is mainstream American media, I focus on the literature that outlines large propaganda systems. For the purposes of this paper, I am using *The Cambridge English Dictionary* definition of mainstream media:

"...forms of the media, especially traditional forms such as newspapers, television, and radio rather than the internet, that influence large numbers of people and are likely to represent generally accepted beliefs and opinions" ("Mainstream Media definition | Cambridge English Dictionary" 2022).

Mainstream media outlets include *The New York Times*, CNN, MSNBC, and *The Washington Post*, among others. Each of these outlets reaches large and influential audiences. The American media system has to be placed within the larger economic, legal, and social contexts to be understood. In my literature review, I examine the role of the mainstream media in American society, scholarship on propaganda, and the legal and economic framework that mainstream media sits within.

Power of the Mainstream Media in America

Mainstream media in the U.S. is extremely powerful. Large outlets like the *New York Times* remain disproportionately influential and have recently increased market share. Related to this, local newspapers have been on the decline. A large catalyst towards the reduction of local

newspapers and smaller outlets has been the widespread availability of national publications on the internet. Data from the Pew Research Center reveals that Sunday paper circulation fell from nearly 30 million weekly to just above 15 million from 2015 to 2020 (Eva Matsa and Worden 2022). A smaller decrease but still notable was the total weekly number of local papers in circulation which fell from 13 million to 8 million in the same period (ibid). The same published report reveals that people are visiting local newspaper's websites more by number of visits; however, the amount of time spent on local newspapers websites has decreased per average visit to just 1.8 minutes per site visit. Because local newspapers have to compete with national and international papers online, people have a stronger tendency to check mainstream sources. As Pew states in a separate report on newspaper circulation, "Using only the AAM (Alliance for Audited Media) data, digital circulation in 2020 is projected to have risen sharply, with weekday papers up 27% and Sunday papers up 26%" (Pew Research Center 2021). *The New York Times* and *The Wall Street Journal*, two of the biggest newspapers in the US, have seen an increase in circulation from 2016 to 2020 when including their digital and print subscriptions (ibid). Another element often discussed in the literature around mainstream media is the difference between print and broadcast media. The rise of television in the 1960s has had drastic changes on how and where Americans get their news. In the 1960s, Americans for the first time, based on self-reported statements, got their news more from television broadcasts than they did from newspapers (Roper, 1978). This shift coincided with the rise of televisions becoming affordable and nearly ubiquitous in the U.S. In a paper written by Steven Chawffee and Stacey Frank, they argue that today print media's audiences tend to be higher educated and already somewhat informed on issues, whereas television broadcasts' audiences tend to be less informed, younger, and more likely to be immigrants (Chaffee and Frank, 1996). Their paper also mentions how less

informed Americans, and those that don't watch or read the news, are less likely to vote. In effect, this gives enormous amounts of power to the news media. If their audiences are more likely to vote, the media's influence on their opinion has more political power.

Social media also has to be noted here. There is a debate in the literature as to whether the pervasiveness of social media has diminished the power of mainstream outlets. Social media companies such as Meta (formerly Facebook), Snapchat, and Youtube (owned by Alphabet), have huge active user populations. In 2021, more than 80% of Americans stated they use Youtube and almost 70% say they use Facebook (Auxier and Anderson 2021). The rise of these sites and the internet as a whole has led to the "unbundling" of content from its publication (Witschge et al. 2016). For example, one no longer needs to go to the New York Times website or subscribe to the print paper to read an article from that news source because it can be shared and viewed on social outlets. The effect of this is not fully understood, but little data shows that this dynamic undermines mainstream media. The number of people who get their news from traditional broadcast and print sources (including websites of print media) still outweighs those who get information from social media (Groot Kormelink and Meijer 2020). Thus, social media has an effect on where or which platform people might receive news, but mainstream outlets remain dominant and most popular. Due to large consolidation, further explored in my literature review, their power has increased due to the shift from print to digital publication.

Propaganda

Media scholarship around propaganda is an interdisciplinary field. There are a variety of disciplines that study propaganda: political science, communication studies, education, economics, and legal studies, to name a few. Beyond the academy, it is a field explored by

governments, militaries, and corporations. This is because effective propaganda can be an incredible tool in the service of power. As Noam Chomsky once put it, "Propaganda is to a democracy what the bludgeon is to a totalitarian state" (Chomsky and Herman, 2002). This is not a new concept and dates back centuries. David Hume, an 18th century Scottish philosopher, once posed that there is a contradiction in unequal societies. He said that the masses, by definition, contain the power in the society and could easily overthrow governments. However, they continually remain obedient to power. His explanation was simple, those that control opinions control the society (Hume, 2015 [Originally published 1768]).[1]

While commonly talked about in the euphemism of public relations, modern American propaganda systems were developed by Edward Bernays and Walter Lippman in the early 20th century (Tye, 2002). In his own words, Lippmann outlined the power of propaganda stating, "the manufacture of consent is capable of great refinements no one, I think, denies. The process by which public opinions arise is certainly no less intricate than it has appeared in these pages, and the opportunities for manipulation open to anyone who understands the process are plain enough."[2] He goes on to say that democracy itself has "turned a corner" and articulates how elite men cannot rely on the public to think for themselves (Lippmann, 1965). Lippmann's ideas about democracy and the power of modern media were influential. He was part of the Creel Committee, one of the United States' first modern efforts towards mass propaganda. The committee's task was not small: they had to rile up the American population into a frenzy to support U.S. involvement in the first World War. Woodrow Wilson was elected on an anti-war platform, famously articulated in his "peace without victory" phrase. However, Wilson's actual

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[1]It is worth noting that Hume wasn't so much critiquing mass propaganda systems as advocating for their existence.

[2] This is the source of the phrase that Chomsky and Herman borrowed for their pivotal work, *Manufacturing Consent*.

intentions were strongly in favor of U.S. involvement (Chomsky, James, and Gordon 2022). He established the Committee on Public Information, otherwise known as CPI or the Creel Committee, and hired Lippmann and other public relations founders to advocate for pro-war policies. The commission was so successful that within a year the U.S. had entered the war (Adams, 1999). In fact, the Council on Foreign Relations once stated it was "the most efficient engine of war propaganda which the world had ever seen" (Tobin and Bidwell, 2021). The effectiveness of the Creel Committee and other public relations efforts demonstrated the power of modern propaganda. Since these efforts, the practice has only become more sophisticated and refined.

Legal and Economic Systems

In this section, I outline the legal system that the American media sits within. The way that propaganda is perpetuated is categorically different from authoritarian states and centralized presses such as *Pravda* in the Soviet System. American media is also distinct in that freedom of speech laws have been strictly enforced since the 1960s with two defining cases: Times V Sullivan (1964) (Wermiel 2009) and Brandenburg V Ohio (1968) (Walker 2009). Each of these cases entrenched freedom of speech for both the press and public individuals advocating criminal activity. Brandenburg V Ohio specifically overturned Schenck V United States among other cases, such that one could only be prosecuted if their speech had "incitement to imminent lawless action" (Global Freedom of Express, Columbia University, n.d.). Times v Sullivan is the modern precedent for defamation lawsuits, establishing the standard of "actual malice" to prove defamation (Brennan 2023). This standard requires plaintiffs to prove that a defendant was not only saying provably false statements, but either knew what they were saying was false or acted

with gross recklessness for the truth, a high standard to meet. These two precedents established the relatively modern legal structure that allows for a range of speech not seen in most countries (Reporters Without Borders 2022).

There is also the economic structure to consider in the U.S.'s propaganda system. This is discussed thoroughly in Edward S. Herman and Noam Chomsky's *Manufacturing Consent* (Chomsky and Herman, 2002). In it, they articulate a Propaganda Model composed of five filters. All filters are relevant to the modern literature around propaganda and two directly relate to the economic structure of American news media: ownership and advertising. The U.S.'s legal and economic structure allows for full control of corporations by individuals and small groups of people with no accountability to the public or stakeholders such as employees and the community in which the business operates. This is opposed to models that force worker representation on Board of Directors such as Germany's Co-Determination laws or large scale industrial cooperatives like Mondragon's (DGB - German Trade Union Confederation, n.d.) (Tang 2019). The current American structure allows for individuals to own entire papers such as Jeff Bezos owning *The Washington Post* or families such as the Murdochs owning News Corp, the parent company of *The Wall Street Journal* and *The New York Post*. This central control allows for coverage that is favorable to the owners and more generally to the dominant class, as these owners have unanimous editorial power and have no accountability beyond market forces. This has shown to have an intense impact of coverage towards more favorable treatment of the owners and their interests (Perez and Sirota, 2022). This ownership is part of a larger trend towards centralization. Media has been consolidated to fewer outlets as local papers decline (Ardia et al. 2022). The impacts of this centralization have resulted in fewer stories about local events and a rightward shift in coverage (Martin and McCrain 2018, 372-384).

If not privately owned by individuals or families, American mainstream media tend to be part of larger corporations with a variety of asset holdings and commercial involvement, all with an explicit for-profit structure.[3] For example, the Comcast Corporation has investments in news media with NBC, CNBC, and MSNBC, investments in cable communications with Comcast and Xfinity, large amounts of real estate with theme parks like Universal Studios, in addition to expansive entertainment sectors which includes NBC, Comedy Central, parts of Dreamworks, BET, and more (SEC Filing, 2022). All of these companies are owned by the larger conglomerate, which has a fiduciary responsibility to make money. This brings up the second filter outlined by Chomsky and Herman, advertising.

Advertising plays a central role in the American propaganda system. Newspapers, TV shows, and newer forms of media, such as podcasts and short form video content, use advertising as a primary funding source. To appeal to advertisers, outlets curate audiences that have disposable income and are typically more influential. This information is not hidden, but rather displayed publicly in an attempt to attract advertisers. *The New York Times* has an "Audience & Insights" tab on their website targeted towards advertisers. It contains facts such as "61% of US opinion leaders turn toward the New York Times" and "4 in 5 Times digital readers are very interested in culture and the arts" (The New York Times 2022). This means newspapers are economically incentivized to curate coverage towards these audiences resulting in the misrepresentation of facts, large omissions of relevant information, and sensationalistic reporting (Taibbi, 2019).

It is the legal and economic system that American media outlets have to operate under that create perverse incentives for outlets to publish the truth. Propaganda comes as a result of filtering mechanisms, where media outlets have to change what they report on and how they

[3] While outside the scope of this paper, this effect creeps into entertainment as well.

report on it to meet economic incentives or to appease elite owners. In analyzing the media's coverage of polarization, these filters will serve as guiding points towards understanding how this process functions.

Literature Review Conclusion

As established earlier, the role of mainstream American media is dominant and deserves careful attention. The legal and economic framework that the media operates within acts as a guiding point, helping explain how and why these distortions happen. In my analysis of primary sources, I review reports by a range of mainstream American media outlets across their print and digital channels. I break down how these outlets report on polarization, the underlying data they use, and how their discourse portrays a false sense of polarization that is overly simplistic and inaccurate.

Methods

Arthur Asa Berger, in *Media Analysis Techniques*, outlines five distinct forms of media analysis: Semiotic Analysis, Marxist Analysis, Psychoanalytic Criticism, Sociological Analysis, and Discourse Analysis (Berger, 2017). While all methodologies are meaningful and are worth applying to the topic at hand, my research focused on using sociological and discourse analysis.

Semiotic analysis is largely attributed to Ferdinand de Saussure who proposed that linguistic signs can be broken down into a concept and a sound-image. De Saussure's work laid the foundation for years of semiotic research and philosophical debate about the meaning and implications of sign systems. Marxist analysis, based on the work of Karl Marx as the name

suggests, is centered around the idea of class struggle. His theories exist within the realm of sociology, politics, and economics. Marxist media analysis has class structures at the core, positing that society should not be viewed as different groups with competing interests, but rather with that of a dominating capital controlling class oppressing the working class. This sort of analysis has been challenged by thinkers such as Daniel Chandler, who states that Marxist "perspectives should not lead us to ignore the various ways in which audiences use the mass media." (Chandler, 2000) In his view, analysis of the reception of different audiences to media should account for different subgroups such as race and gender. This is contradictory to the binary proposed by Marxist analysis between an oppressive capitalist class and an oppressed proletariat. Psychoanalytical criticism is centered around understanding how individuals respond to stimuli, specifically exploring the unconscious desires of spectators. Inherent to this methodology is that stimulus, for example in film, books, and audio, cannot be viewed as neutral. Rather, one's desires shape their perception and understanding of the world, and therefore, each spectator will react to media differently (McGowan and Kearney, 2018). Semiotic, Marxist, and psychoanalytical media analysis are important tools in media criticism. Understanding how the media represents the opinions of large groups of people is worthy of lots of different types of analysis. However, in my paper I primarily rely on the latter two listed by Berger, sociological and discourse analysis because it allows for the clearest contrast in what the media reports and the underlying data they use to draw their conclusions.

Sociological analysis builds upon psychoanalytical analysis in attempting to understand and represent the views of large groups of people. However, the orthodox view around sociological analysis diverges from psychoanalytical approaches in believing that public opinion exists and simply must be measured, as expressed famously by pollster George Gallup (Roper

Center for Public Opinion Research 2023). While there has been criticism, such as in Bordieu's *Public Opinion Does Not Exist*, this sociological view has maintained dominance (Bourdieu, 2010) and continues to be used by many journalists, consciously or not, as they report on polling. This analysis has large implications for my paper as polls are part of the foundation of discourse around polarization. While criticism is justified, such as Barbara Johnstone's work examining the inconsistencies of poll takers via telephone, polls nonetheless serve as an important tool in understanding public opinion (Johnstone, 1991). While inconsistent, polls are the basis for numerous news articles. As I will show later in this paper, there are large inconsistencies between the narrative of news articles covering the results of polls and the polls themselves. Their importance can further be measured by their widespread use in the public relations industry (Johnstone, 2018). As Noam Chomsky puts it, "[polls] are business initiated. Propaganda institutions like PR agencies want to keep their finger on the public pulse." (*Public Opinion Polls | Noam Chomsky* 2022) Discourse analysis is centered around the phrases, utterances, and the context in which language is used. I use it to understand what journalists are reporting and what they are omitting, either from polls or from a larger political and social context. Specifically, it takes into account how political discourse utilizes shared history and cultural moments to connect with one's audience (Çakırtaş, 2019). Using discourse analysis, one can show how text portrays certain ideas and how an audience understands those ideas. It goes beyond using simple quotations by seeking to understand how the text was produced, disseminated, and consumed. Looking through the lens of sociological analysis and discourse analysis demonstrates how the media portrays certain topics and their relationship between the production of knowledge and the audience receiving it.

Background

While this paper is not making an argument about what Americans believe directly, a brief summary of American viewpoints on political issues is revealing. Polling of American viewpoints provides a mixed picture, one where in addition to division, consensus is often found. I will briefly summarize these findings in contrast to the common narrative that the U.S. is divided. For example,

- 79% agree that healthcare should be universal (Sanger 2019)
- 70% agree that Roe shouldn't have been overturned (Pew Research Center 2019)
- 72% acknowledge the climate crisis and over 65% support carbon taxes (Marlon et al. 2022)
- 88% support cannabis legalization in some form, with 59% legal for recreational use (Van Green 2022)
- 71% support same sex marriage (Gallup 2022)
- 86% agree racism is a problem in America and 68% think teaching about racism will help (Backus and Salvanto 2022)
- 89% pro-background checks for guns, 86% support red flag laws (Deliso 2022)
- 77% want to limit money in politics (Jones 2018)

These statistics are not to argue that there is no division or disagreement amongst Americans. And there certainly are cases where Americans will poll roughly evenly and will be divided across race, class, geography, and other factors. However, if most Americans agree on questions concerning healthcare, abortion rights, gun control, campaign finance, and more, there is something missing when the majority of Americans, 85%, also believes that we are "divided in [our] values" (Peoples and Fingerhut 2020).

Essential to understanding the media's coverage of division across the country are important contextual factors. These are: the power of mainstream American media, the institutional structure of such media and its biases, and the structure of democratic representation

in the United States. There are two primary sources of revenue for the mainstream media. One product is the content itself is put behind a paywall. According to Reuters Institute, in collaboration with the University of Oxford, more than 75% of leading newspapers operate some kind of paywall, a trend that is increasing (Simon and Graves 2019). The other is the media viewer's attention, which is sold to advertisers (Pew Research Center 2021). The economic model of mainstream media incentivises sensationalistic and misleading reporting. As Edward Herman and Noam Chomsky put it in *Manufacturing Consent*, "It is their function to amuse, entertain, and inform, and to inculcate individuals with the values, beliefs, and codes of behavior that will integrate them into the institutional structures of the larger society. In a world of concentrated wealth and major conflicts of class interest, to fulfill this role requires systematic propaganda" (Chomsky and Herman 2002, p. 61).

I will demonstrate that the mainstream media conflate the United States's current system of a flawed representational democracy with a perfect democracy, where power is distributed equally amongst citizens. There are two institutional factors that are undemocratic which shape the state of our politics: the Senate and the electoral college. The electoral college is a system in which citizens do not directly vote for the president, but elect delegates who then vote for the president. This system gives citizens living in states with populations small enough to have a single Congressional representative in the House of Representatives, such as North Dakota and Alaska, more power. In the last six elections, two presidents have been elected despite losing the popular vote: George W. Bush in 2000 and Donald Trump in 2016 (Lau 2021). The Senate also has institutional features which result in citizens of smaller states getting more electoral power than their counterparts living in more populated states. Every state, regardless of population, gets two senators. This system, even more than the electoral college, favors voters in smaller states.

As Al From, founder of the Democratic Leadership Council and adjunct professor at Johns Hopkins University, wrote, "The root of the institutional imbalance is in the structure of the United States Senate" (From 2022). These two systems enable America's legislative, executive, and by continuation, judicial branches of government to be undemocratic and non-representative of constituents.

While the Senate and electoral college are institutionally biased against democracy, due to power being unevenly distributed amongst different citizens, there are other factors that weaken American democracy. Notably, gerrymandering and systems of campaign finance corrode democratic systems. Gerrymandering is the conscious process of drawing electoral maps in one's favor. This can be done with the practice of "cracking", when one dilutes an opposition vote by spreading members of a specific party and political affiliation across multiple districts, or by "packing", where one concentrates all oppositional party members in one district, ensuring the surrounding districts do not have to deal with members of that party and political affiliation. The practice is widespread and results in the House of Representatives not representative of the American population as a whole.[4] Political scientists have shown that gerrymandering has given Republicans a net of 16 to 17 seats in the House across the 2010-2020 census maps. This figure is damning and even more so considering Democrats also engage in the practice, meaning upwards of 20 seats have been crafted to represent specific political parties, resulting in a lack of representation in the House for the population as a whole (Kirschenbaum and Li 2021).

While the Senate and presidential races have institutional bias against democratic representation, and the House is subject to widespread gerrymandering, all races are inherently not fully democratic due to financial campaign laws. Campaign financing and greed have been

[4] Gerrymandering is also done at the state level. For the purposes of this paper I focus solely on the federal electoral districts.

core to America since its founding. Over 100 years ago Marcus Hanna, a Republican senator in the late 19th century, said “There are two things that are important in politics. The first is money and I can't remember what the second one is" (Civil Politics 2014). Recently however, the influence of money has grown substantially (Brennan Center for Justice 2018). Not only has wealth inequality grown in America over the past 60 years, (Piketty 2021) but the regulation of money in politics has loosened. Notably in 2010, Citizens United V FEC allowed for unlimited campaign spending by corporations and other groups (Lau and Pino 2019). Data shows that money correlates to electoral wins in both the House of Representatives and the Senate to a staggering degree. Analysis of all congressional races between 2000 and 2016 shows that House candidates who raised more money won more than 90% of the time and Senate candidates won more than 80% of the time on average (Koerth 2018). Political analysis of elections going back decades show this trend, with some fluctuations and outliers (Ferguson 1995). In summary, money is not distributed equally in the country and because people and corporations can donate unlimited amounts of money, and that money has impacts on our elections, some people have unjust influence on our representatives.

Due to institutional biases against the Democratic party at the executive branch and in the Senate, with gerrymandering affecting the role of the House of Representatives, and with money’s influence across all political races, it would be wrong to assume legislation is a reflection of the will of the people. These elements are not the only influences on our electoral system but constitute enough of a bias that true democratic representation has not been fulfilled.

The consensus of American opinion on numerous political issues, the power of the mainstream media, and the undemocratic nature of America’s electoral systems each provide a necessary piece of understanding mainstream news coverage of American division.

Argument and Analysis

The American mainstream media consistently provides a false view on American division and the state of American polarization. They do so not by outright lying or falsifying data, but by deploying filtering mechanisms which distort perspective. Based on research, I identify four filtering mechanisms by which this happens: cherry-picking data, sensationalistic headlines, assumption of perfect democracy[5] in the United States, and an overemphasis on people and anecdotes. I want to note that my thesis is not arguing that mainstream media never portray Americans as unified in their beliefs, as they will report on polls with widespread agreement. However, it is that when the media portray Americans as divided, it is done so not by accurately representing data, but by putting that data through one of the aforementioned filtering mechanisms. Below I examine individual articles, how they report on polarization and division, and the consistent discrepancies between the narratives and the underlying data they use in their coverage.

Cherry-Picking

Cherry-picking data is selectively choosing statistics and findings for the purpose of promoting a specific agenda. This is not a new phenomenon and it is a nuanced practice, as articles by definition are summaries. Cherry-picking can be used to paint almost any narrative, as Mark Twain alluded to in a famous quote.[6] In my research on mainstream media, I show how the practice is used to portray Americans as divided in spite of contradictory evidence. This practice

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[5] Throughout this paper I will use the term “perfect democracy.” By this, I am referring to a system of democratic control of the state, judged by broad participation, voter enfranchisement, and majority rule.
[6] "There are three kinds of lies: lies, damned lies and statistics."

allows large, mainstream media outlets to report on data suggesting some level of polarization or division, without providing a needed context.

For example, *The New York Times* published a piece spotlighting how political divides relate to interpersonal relationships. The article, titled *Today's Politics Divide Parties, and Friends and Families, Too,* published in October of 2022, is entirely based on a poll conducted by *The New York Times* and Siena College. While the article's title and contents contend that Americans are divided politically and socially, the poll itself offers evidence to the contrary. The subheading for the article is "In the latest poll by The New York Times and Siena College, nearly one in five voters said that politics hurt their friendships or family relationships." Their leading result is accurate to their poll. However, there is a series of misleading statements as well as numerous data omitted in the article that was collected in the poll. For example, the article states: "Close to half of the voters in the survey also acknowledged making judgments about other people based on their politics. Forty-eight percent of those polled said that knowing a person's political views told them either a lot or a little about whether someone was a good person." This framing is misleading, as it makes one believe that almost half of poll respondents make judgements big or small. The actual data from the survey respondents are as such:

- 14% said one's politics tell you if someone is a good person,
- 34% said one's politics only tell you a little if someone is a good person,
- 40% said it doesn't tell you anything about someone being a good person
- the remaining 12% did not respond or did not know.

The distinction between these questions is crucial and conflating them is misleading. The framing could have been the large agreement 74%, that survey respondents believe that one's politics tells someone either "a little" or "does not tell you" if someone is a good person or the article could have provided the full context with each statistic individually. There is other data that is simply omitted such as 84% (of those who said democracy is under threat) say mainstream

media is a major or minor threat (59% and 25% respectively) to democracy. This large consensus is completely omitted from the article. Both the misleading data as well as the omitted data have a commonality: they do not support the assumed claim that Americans are divided.

Another article from the New York Times, published in October of 2019, proclaims America cannot agree on health. The article is titled “How Americans Split on Health Care: It’s a 3 Way Tie” (Sanger 2019). However, like the previous article, data is framed in a misleading way. Most notably is the framing of the article in the title’s language. One has to scroll to almost the end of the article to read that 80% of Americans, according to their poll, want a universal healthcare system, responding yes to the question “is healthcare a right”. This includes a majority of people who supported the Republican healthcare bill, with 60% viewing healthcare as a right. The article does contain Americans' disagreement about the correct plan for healthcare, with people evenly split amongst the three options presented to them: Medicare-For-All, Expanding the Affordable Care Act, or the Republican healthcare bill in 2019. However, there is also significant data omitted from the article that contains widespread agreement. The following data is the percentage total of the entire polling group:

- 96% don’t have a “great deal of public trust in” pharmaceutical companies,
- 96% don’t have a “great deal of public trust in” health insurance companies,
- 95% don’t have a “great deal of public trust in” congress,
- 95% don’t have a “great deal of public trust in” business leaders,
- 82% favor government requiring health insurance companies to include those with pre-existing conditions,
- 80% have a positive view of Medicare,
- 70% have a positive view of Medicaid,
- 79% believe all Americans should have a right to health care regardless of their ability to pay.

All of the above data, except for the last statistic, was omitted from the article despite being present in the poll the article reportedly summarized. The last statistic is mentioned near

the end of the large with a nod to some consensus. However, it is then framed from a quote by David Blumenthal, president of the private foundation the Commonwealth Fund, saying

> ‘Most Americans want everyone to have coverage, but some people are willing to sacrifice more to get there than others,’ Mr. Blumenthal said. “The people who are willing to sacrifice more are the people who have less to lose.’

This framing echoes the narrative that Americans are divided over healthcare. If the article were to represent the poll accurately, it would include either the data and/or summarize it to show widespread agreement amongst Americans.

Both of these examples demonstrate how data selectively chosen from polls can create a narrative of division. They also demonstrate that Americans have widespread agreement on issues. Through cherry-picking data, the authors were able to craft a narrative around division that is not consistent with the underlying data.

Sensationalistic Bias

The media’s sensationalistic bias towards gripping headlines creates misleading tones for articles. Take a series of New York Times headlines that presuppose that the US is “divided” and “polarized”: “In a Nation Divided, one Area of Agreement: Voting Matters”, (Nagourney 2022) “Trump Inquiries Present a Stress Test for Justice in a Polarized Nation”, (Goldman 2023) “A Nation Divided at Inauguration” (Bracken et al. 2017). All of these articles infer division in the US however, they do not argue or prove this division. Yet, through this inference they create false equivalences between segments of the population. For example, the former most article leads with the following paragraph, “They had been assured that they were wasting their time. That the fix was in. That a fair outcome was impossible, what with all that Democratic ballot-rigging — or was it Republican voter suppression?” The article then goes on to discuss

historically high voter turnout. Not only does the headline lean towards the sensationalistic idea of a divided nation, but the leading paragraph creates a scandalous comparison between Republican voter suppression, which has been documented for years (Morris and Wilder 2022), and Democratic "ballot-rigging", which has no substantial evidence to back the claim (Wang 2012). These falsehoods create a misleading framing to portray two equally divisive and problematic sides. Not only is the premise false but it does not correlate with American views on the election. According to a Pew survey, taken after the 2020 election, the majority of Americans believe (correctly) that Biden won the election (Pew Research Center 2021).

Another example of sensationalist headlines comes from a CNN article published in November of 2016 titled "CNN/ORC poll: A nation divided, and is it ever" (Agiesta 2016). The article's title contradicts data summarized in the article. The article outright states in the second paragraph, "The poll's findings… also suggest a sizable minority personally agree with both parties on at least some issues, and nearly 8-in-10 overall hope to see the GOP-controlled government incorporate some Democratic policies into its agenda." This alone questions the headline with a "sizeable minority" having bipartisan agreement. The rest of the poll centers around American viewpoints on political parties and politicians, ignoring American viewpoints on political issues themselves. The title here suggests a uniquely divided nation however, all evidence points to division surrounding viewpoints of political parties and politicians. By failing to ask Americans their viewpoints on issues themselves and omitting any data that would provide that context, the headline over sensationalizes the poll and fails to inform its readers.

Sensationalistic headlines not only frame how a reader views an article, but the majority of people don't read beyond the headline and of those that get past it, people tend to skim the rest

(Cillizza 2014). Because of this, sensationalistic headlines are particularly problematic as they are more likely than not, all a reader sees.

Conflation Between the U.S. Electoral System and a Perfect Democracy

Another filtering mechanism is the conflation between the United States' electoral system and an ideal representative democracy. Relying on data outlined in both my literature review and background, there are large barriers that influence democratic control of elected representatives. There are also large segments of the population that may generally vote with one of the two dominant US political parties, but identify as independents or with another political party. In a news analysis published in February of 2023 by the New York Times, called *For Biden, a Chance for a Fresh Start in a New Era of Divided Government*, there is a conflation between Congress and the US public. The analysis states "the state of America's union is disunion. To see that, [Biden] will need only turn around to find a Republican House speaker seated behind him, determined to block his every move" (Baker 2023). While the piece correctly points out that Republicans seek to essentially block any piece of legislation put forth by Democrats, (Tausanovitch, Amjad, and Chang 2019) there is no mention of the undemocratic features of our electoral system, nor how Congresspeople do not necessarily represent the viewpoints of their constituents. The analysis continues with this conflation, between the US, implying all citizens and residents, and Congress. The analysis quotes Peter H. Wehner, the former director of strategic initiatives for President George W. Bush, who states "sometimes having divided government actually helps you politically because it allows you, as president, to present your agenda as eminently reasonable, meaning that only unreasonable people would oppose what you're trying to do." The notion here of reasonableness plays into the idea that, through

democratic representation, consensus will always come to a reasonable proposal. However, in an undemocratic system proposals that are "reasonable", essentially meaning bipartisan, do not reflect the will of the people. Wehner goes on to say that "Biden's been dealt a pretty good hand if you want to portray the opposition as extreme and racial – because they are." The article then describes the political benefit of Biden portraying Republicans as extreme, the expected Republican response to Biden's State of the Union address, and what Biden will use the speech for. Very briefly in the second to last paragraph of the article, there isn't any coverage of American viewpoints; however, the coverage is of Republican views on the "border crisis" and Biden's approval rating. What is implicit in the article is that Congress represents the will of the electorate. There is no discussion of the real barriers that exist to democratic representation. In an interview published by National Public Radio, one can see the conflation similar to *The New York Times*' News Analysis. Host Steve Inskeep spoke with Allan Lichtman, a professor of history at American University, about "the country's polarization" and its effect on political dynasties. Throughout the interview, Lichtman provides no evidence for American polarization. He goes on to say "[Liz Cheney's loss in Wyoming] wasn't about issues at all. Let me make that clear. Liz Cheney is a staunch conservative. She voted over 90% of the time with [Trump]. She's perfectly in step with the conservative ideology of her party. She rarely voted with Joe Biden. This had nothing whatsoever to do with issues and everything to do with adhering to the big lie, which has now become the basis of the Republican Party" (Inskeep and Lichtman 2022). This notion that the election was not about "issues" but rather about the Big Lie continually plays into the assumption that the voters get to decide their representatives in a fair process. Wyoming, a state with a small population, has a single at-large congressional representative. As such, certainly for Wyoming, gerrymandering is not relevant in the election. However, the two-party

system, specifically the closed primary system and the influence of money are not mentioned. Both Cheney and Hageman raised millions of dollars for their campaigns, including from Super PACs and corporations (Miller 2022). Furthermore, only 40.8% of the eligible voting population voted in Wyoming's 2022 primary election where Cheney was unseated (Wyoming Election Division 2022). This is not part of the analysis by NPR albeit crucial in understanding Wyoming's change in representation.

The conflation between the United States's current electoral system and a perfect democracy has large implications for the future of electoral politics. If the narrative is that the country is divided and the future is going to get worse (Daniller 2023), and the current power system is more or less a democracy, then faith in democracy itself diminishes. The media's continual omission of structural undemocratic elements as well as their assumed conflation between the status quo and a perfect democracy further erode trust in democracy itself.

Overemphasis on Anecdotes

Furthermore, through an overemphasis on people and anecdotal stories, mainstream news misleads its audience. Local news outlets are known for running stories spotlighting local events. National outlets use similar tactics with broader implications. For example, The New York Times ran a story about one family's approach to living together in a politically diverse household. The article's headline, "Family Ties. Political Divisions." plays into an overly sensationalist headline. The first quarter of the article is exclusively about a single family, the Broes, living in Scottsdale, Arizona. It discusses how they have different mailboxes, can't discuss politics anymore, and how at one point, a family member moved into a hotel due to household tension. The article then states, "Their story would be extraordinary were it not so ordinary in America," then stating a

couple paragraphs after that, “The Broes happen to be the perfect embodiment of their surroundings” (Medina 2022). However, there is no data or context provided for the fact that politics divides families across the US as it does in the Broes family. The article simply states it as fact. Evidence is given for political separation of parties across county lines and that Scottsdale was almost perfectly split between Biden and Trump in 2020. This plays into aforementioned filtering mechanisms as well, in other words that the US is democratic and that politics represent American’s viewpoints. The article finishes where it started, with stories about the Broes and their approach to politics. In some ways, even their own reporting seems to contradict itself, saying “On most days, the Broes function as any other family does — like a kind of small business, everyone working to fulfill agreed-upon duties and obligations, amid a steady mix of humor, boredom and love.” Assuming this family is accurately represented in the article, the author states that their political disagreements and strife are suggestions of a divided country. However, there is no evidence of this.

The overemphasis on anecdotes is dangerous as a single story can be used to tell any narrative. Combined with the previous three filtering mechanisms, anecdotes can be extra effective. As seen in the article above, there is a combination of the conflation filtering mechanism as well as the overemphasis on anecdotes.

Analysis

One can see each of the four filtering mechanisms used throughout mainstream media. They are specifically used when discussing the nature of American division and polarization; however, they have been utilized since the beginning of the public relations industry (Tobin and Bidwell 2021). The implications for the consistent misrepresentation of American viewpoints are

especially alarming. In the 2020 Pew Trust article entitled "How Americans View Trust, Facts, and Democracy Today," Dr. Michael Dimock explains how trust in democratic institutions and the U.S. electorate is diminishing. He states, "fully 73 percent of the public says that most Republican and Democratic voters not only disagree over plans and policies, but also disagree on 'basic facts.'" (Dimock 2020) The trendline for this trust continues to diminish with troubling projections. There is a clear disconnect between what people believe and what they think about others, as the majority of people agree on political issues but have little faith others see issues like they do. Mainstream media institutions, with their disproportionate influence and power, are contributing to the lack of trust in democratic institutions and eroding public discourse. Despite the nuanced nature of American opinion, mainstream media continues to claim that Americans are divided in politics and people believe it. Through cherry-picking data points, sensationalistic headlines, conflation between the United State's electoral system and a perfect democracy, and an overemphasis on anecdotal stories, mainstream media provides an inflated sense of division.

These findings are consistent with research on American propaganda and how particularly mainstream media contributes to a propaganda system that entrenches elite power (Chomsky and Herman 2002). If Americans were to understand how much they agree with each other, one can envision how logical follow up questions could be asked. For example, one might ask why people previously thought they disagreed with each other? Why politicians weren't representing the will of their constituents? Or why our electoral system has large undemocratic elements? These questions endanger the ruling class, as by definition, they would change the status quo that benefits them. In the history of Americans asking questions like these that challenge elite people and institutions, one can see backlash. For instance, after the mass protests of the 1960s, future Supreme Court Justice Lewis Powell wrote a memorandum to the U.S.

Chamber of Commerce. In it, he spoke about the need for business executives to stop the assault on the "free enterprise system," by staffing schools, speaking on campuses, and rewriting textbooks to defend the current oppressive system. As he laid out, business leaders have "little skill in effective intellectual and philosophical debate" (Powell 1971). Because of this, they must resort to keeping the population from asking these questions. One can see how a dominant media, part of a larger propaganda system, would serve the status quo well by portraying a nation as divided in spite of the evidence.

Conclusion

Individual journalists have a simple obligation: to discover, summarize, and report the truth. The role of media analyses has a similar objective. My analysis is meant to inform viewers, readers, particularly those that are more engaged, to understand how the publications that inform our view of the world can be biased, and in many cases, how they fail to inform us about each other's views.[7]

The four filtering mechanisms are dominant throughout media coverage of all types but seem particularly in play when discussing American viewpoints. Through this analysis, I hope to add to the larger body of literature that seeks to understand how information is distorted through our news systems.

The profit motive, along with the legal systems that allow for consolidation and ownership of news media, is a ripe environment for distortion. Recently, American division is in the headlines but there is a long history of important political issues not being represented accurately by mainstream news; whether it is the history of the revolutionary war or American

[7] Assuming Americans are reading this. To my international audience, I do not believe your views are represented accurately either but that is a separate paper.

imperialism, mainstream media upholds current power systems by distorting the facts to perpetuate the status quo.

The role of mainstream media is shifting, but it still heavily influences our perceptions. Its consistent failure to present the needed context surrounding American viewpoints, whether covering them directly or covering politics more broadly, has large implications. As stated at the beginning of the paper, Americans view themselves as polarized, with 85% of registered voting describing America as divided in its values (Peoples and Fingerhut 2020). When a population both believes it is failing and is being represented democratically, then faith in democracy dwindles, creating a perfect opportunity for conmen and fascists to take hold.

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